MGM HEALTHCARE AT THE CUTTING EDGE OF HEART & LUNG TRANSPLANTS

The Institute of Heart and Lung Transplant and Mechanical Circulatory Support at MGM Healthcare – Chennai, spearheaded by India's leading heart and lung transplant surgeon Dr K.R. Balakrishnan as its Director, was set up with the vision to utilise the latest in technology, innovation and medical protocols to give patients with heart failure a new lease of life. The advanced technology, infrastructure and equipment available at MGM Healthcare, combined with skilled physicians and surgeons, provides improved diagnosis, care, treatment and outcomes for heart patients.

While heart transplants have been around for a while, over the last decade they have taken off in a big way. One of the pioneers in transplants is MGM Healthcare – Chennai, which runs the largest heart and lung transplant programme in South Asia, conducting over 100 transplants a year, with a high 10-year survival rate of over 75 percent in the case of heart transplants.

Spearheading MGM Healthcare's pioneering Institute of Heart and Lung Transplant and Mechanical Circulatory Support is Dr K.R. Balakrishnan, whose areas of expertise include end-stage heart failure management (heart transplant & VAD implant, lung transplant, combined heart & lung transplant). Dr Balakrishnan takes an evidence-based approach to healthcare practices and is known for his refined clinical expertise in surgery. He has received numerous awards for his work and has published in the highest-ranking international medical journals.

From the successful use of ECMO, a machine that provides heart and lung support to a person in end-stage heart and lung failure, as a bridge to heart transplant in 2012 to India's first successful HVAD implant surgery performed on a 42-year-old with end-stage heart failure to the first paediatric heart transplant on a two-year-old,

Dr K.R. Balakrishnan and his team of highly skilled surgeons and physicians have performed many 'firsts' for India.

WHEN IS A TRANSPLANT REQUIRED?

A patient needs a heart transplant in cases of advanced heart failure when all other options are exhausted. “At end of medical therapy, if the heart is still not working properly, the blood pressure is not stable, the lung pressure is high, and the patient is requiring repeated hospitalisation every few weeks, then a heart transplant may be the last resort,” says Dr Balakrishnan. According to him, heart transplants are required when the heart's pumping efficiency falls to around 15 percent. This would constitute severe heart failure.

Being diagnosed with heart failure means that your heart is unable to pump enough blood to effectively cater to your body's needs. Heart failure may be caused by a variety of reasons ranging from coronary artery disease to high blood pressure, leaking or blocked valves, cardiomyopathy, viral cardiac infections, and inherited or congenital cardiac disease. Children who have been administered certain medicines for leukaemia or women whose hearts have been weakened by pregnancy/childbirth may also experience heart failure.

PREPARING FOR A TRANSPLANT

The team of cardiologists and cardiac surgeons at MGM Healthcare, led by Dr KR Balakrishnan, is well equipped to address these concerns. If someone is a candidate for a heart transplant, a team of heart transplant surgeons will initially assess their eligibility for a heart transplant. They will then be briefed on the risks involved. The patient's medical history, test results and social history will also be evaluated, and psychological tests will be conducted to analyse where and how the patient might need support during and after surgery. If deemed suitable and willing to have a heart transplant, the patient will be registered

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